

Day 3 — Detailed — Monday, August 10, 2026 — Going-to-the-Sun Road

Hungry Horse → Going-to-the-Sun Road → Logan Pass → St. Mary → Many Glacier → St. Mary Village
Sun: Rise 6:18 / Set 8:50 · **Logan Pass:** high 68°F, WSW 6-13 mph gusting 22 · **St. Mary:** high 77°F **Smoke:** forecast carries "Smoke" all day both at Logan Pass and St. Mary 🏠 **Tonight:** St. Mary Village · conf 73478287602240 · \$409 · **24-hour front desk** · 406-732-4431

Key change: you are NOT stopping at the hotel before the boat. Everything you need for the boat and for the rest of the day travels with you from the moment you leave Hungry Horse.

The Three Hard Constraints

Everything below is built around these. Nothing else on the day is fixed.

#	Constraint	Consequence
1	Boat tour 5:00 PM , ticket office by 4:30	Must leave the St. Mary area by 3:45 PM , no exceptions
2	Logan Pass parking capped at 3 hours (enforced, new July 2026)	Park at 8:00 → out by 11:00
3	Construction delays up to 30 min on a one-way crossing	Buffer is built in; if you don't use it, you gain time on the east side

Before You Leave — Pack List

You will not see your luggage again until ~8 PM tonight. Pack the car completely before you go.

In a daypack, accessible, not in the trunk:

- **Warm layers for the boat** — this is the one people get wrong. It'll be 77°F at St. Mary in the afternoon, but you're on open water at 6 PM at 4,900 ft. Fleece or puffy + a wind layer. A hat.
- **3-4 L of water each.** Smoke plus exertion plus 6,600 ft dehydrates you fast. There is no water on the Highline or Hidden Lake.
- **N95 masks** — for the hikes if the air is bad.
- **Bear spray**, accessible, not buried. Hidden Lake and the Highline are both active bear terrain.
- Sunscreen, sunglasses, lip balm. High-altitude sun cuts through smoke haze.
- Lunch and snacks from your groceries. **There is no food between Logan Pass and Rising Sun.**
- Headlamp (for tonight's aurora attempt, and it lives in the daypack now).

Settle the Mini Golden Inns bill tonight or leave the key in the room — there's no 24-hour desk and you're leaving before anyone's up.

The Schedule

6:00 AM — Up and out

Coffee, load the car, final check that boat layers are in the daypack.

6:15 AM — Depart Hungry Horse

Sunrise is 6:18, so you'll drive into it. **Expect the valley to be smoky** — the overnight inversion won't have broken yet. This is the worst air of your day and you'll be in a car for it. That's by design.

6:30 AM — West Glacier Entrance (*≈15 min*)

Pass in hand, use the pass-holder lane. No vehicle reservations required in 2026.

6:40 AM — Apgar / Lake McDonald pullouts (*optional, 10 min*)

Mile 0-10. If the lake is glassy, the pullouts along the east shore are worth a two-minute stop. Early morning is the best reflection window of the day. **Don't linger** — the Logan Pass clock is what matters.

6:55 AM — Lake McDonald Lodge (*pass by*)

Mile 10. You ate here yesterday. Keep driving.

7:05 AM — Avalanche Creek — *decision point (optional, 45 min)*

Mile 16. If you never got to **Trail of the Cedars** yesterday, this is your last chance — it's a flat 1-mile boardwalk loop through old-growth red cedar and hemlock, with the turquoise Avalanche Gorge. ~45 min.

The trade: taking it puts you at Logan Pass around 8:45 instead of 7:45, which is inside the window when the lot starts filling. **If you already did the Cedars yesterday, skip it and drive on.**

➖ **Avalanche Lake is not recoverable today.** It's 5.8 miles and 3–3.5 hours. Doing it would cost you Logan Pass parking, Hidden Lake, and the Highline. Hidden Lake Overlook is the better hike and it sits above the smoke. Let it go.

7:20 AM — The Loop

Mile 24. The big hairpin switchback where the road starts climbing in earnest. Pullout with views back down the McDonald valley. **2 min stop.** From here the road narrows and clings to the mountainside — this is where Going-to-the-Sun becomes what it's famous for.

7:30 AM — Bird Woman Falls Overlook

Mile 26. Across the valley, a 492-ft waterfall dropping out of a hanging valley between Mt. Oberlin and Mt. Cannon. **2 min.** Haze may soften it — it's a distance view.

7:35 AM — Weeping Wall

Mile 27. Water sheets straight off the rock face onto the road. Lighter in August than in June but still flowing. **Roll your window down and drive through it slowly.** No stop needed — there's a small pullout just past it if you want the photo.

7:40 AM — Haystack Falls / Big Bend / Triple Arches

Miles 28-30. Three quick pullouts in a row. **Big Bend** is the best of them — a wide sweeping turn with the Garden Wall towering above and the valley falling away. Mountain goats and bighorn sheep are regularly seen on the rock faces here. **5 min total.**

7:50 AM — Oberlin Bend Overlook

Mile 31.5. A short boardwalk just below the pass, and **the single most reliable mountain goat spot on the road.** Often better than Logan Pass itself for them. **5 min** — and if there's a goat, take it, because you may not get closer.

8:00 AM — LOGAN PASS — park the car 🕒

Mile 32 • 6,646 ft • Continental Divide

🕒 **THE 3-HOUR CLOCK STARTS NOW. You must be out by 11:00 AM.**

Arriving at 8:00 on a Monday should get you a spot without drama — the lot historically fills around 9:00. If it's somehow full, wait 10 minutes in the lot rather than driving on; turnover at this hour is quick.

Visitor center opens at 8:00 AM (restrooms are open earlier). Use the bathroom here — the next real one is Rising Sun, four hours away.

Air quality note: at 6,646 ft you're likely *above* the valley inversion that's been trapping smoke down at Lake McDonald. This may be the best air you've breathed since you arrived. Expect hazy distance views regardless — the Garden Wall and Reynolds Mountain are close enough to read well, but the far peaks will wash out.

Layer up. It'll be around 50°F with WSW wind gusting to 22 mph. It feels much colder than the 68°F daytime high suggests.

⚠️ **Elevation note — read before you start**

You flew in from sea level 48 hours ago, you're standing at 6,646 ft, and there's smoke in the air. That stack hits harder than any trail profile suggests.

The good news: the Highline Trail is flat. It is also the best thing up here. Your one real climb today is Hidden Lake, and it's the easiest trail on the whole itinerary to turn around on.

Priority order: Highline is the must-do. Hidden Lake is the stretch goal.

- **Pace to conversation.** If you're too winded to talk, you're going too fast. Slowing down works better than stopping.
- **Short, frequent breaks** beat long ones.
- **Drink more than feels necessary.** Dehydration at altitude imitates altitude sickness almost exactly.
- **Turning around early is not failing.** Every trail today is worth it partway.

8:15 AM — Hidden Lake Overlook (▲ up to 2.7 mi RT • 540 ft gain • ~1.5-2 hrs)

Trailhead: directly behind the Logan Pass Visitor Center.

- First **0.7 mi is boardwalk**, climbing steadily through alpine meadow. In early August this should still be wildflowers — glacier lily, beargrass, Indian paintbrush.
- Then it transitions to dirt and rock for the final stretch to the overlook at **1.35 mi**.
- **Snow patches are common here even in August.** They're usually short and easily crossed, but they're slick — take them slowly.
- **Wildlife:** this is the best mountain goat trail in the park. Also bighorn sheep, hoary marmots, and ptarmigan. Goats here are habituated and often walk right past the boardwalk. **Stay 25 yards back** regardless of how calm they look.
- **The overlook** looks down on Hidden Lake with **Bearhat Mountain** rising behind it — a near-perfect pyramid. This is the money shot of the day and it's close-range enough that smoke won't ruin it.

⊖ **Do not descend to the lake itself.** It's 1.2 mi further down and 765 ft of climbing to get back out. It would eat your Highline time and your parking clock.

🎯 **The bail-out points, in order — all of them are a good day:**

- **0.5 mi (boardwalk, ~150 ft):** you've already seen the meadow, the wildflowers, and most likely the goats. **This is where the value is concentrated.** Turning around here costs you very little.
- **0.7 mi (end of boardwalk, ~300 ft):** big open views back toward Reynolds Mountain and Clements Mountain. A completely satisfying turnaround.
- **1.35 mi (the overlook, 540 ft):** Bearhat Mountain over Hidden Lake. The full payoff — take it if the climb is going well.

Back at the car by ~10:00 regardless of how far you got.

10:05 AM — Highline Trail (▲ 1.5-2 mi RT · essentially flat · ~1 hr)

★ **The must-do. Roughly 100 ft of gain over a mile and a half — the best view-to-effort ratio in the park. Trailhead: across the road from the Logan Pass parking lot.** Look for the crosswalk.

- **The first 0.3 mi is the famous ledge** — the trail is carved into a cliff face with a sheer drop on your left and a **bolted garden-hose cable** at shoulder height to hold. It is genuinely safe and the tread is wide enough, but if either of you is uneasy with exposure, this is the part to know about in advance. Hold the cable, look at your feet, keep moving.
- Past the ledge it opens into a **flat traverse beneath the Garden Wall**, the knife-edge arête of the Continental Divide. The valley drops 1,000+ ft below you the entire way.
- **Walk 45 minutes out and turn around.** That gets you well past the cable section into the open traverse where the view is best. Haystack Butte is 3.5 mi out and Granite Park Chalet is 7.6 — both far beyond today.
- Watch for **bighorn sheep** on the slopes above and **marmots** in the talus.

Back at the car by ~11:00.

11:00 AM — Depart Logan Pass 🕒

Parking limit is up. Go.

11:10 AM — Lunch Creek

Mile 33.5. Just past the East Side Tunnel. A cascading creek tumbling down slabs with **Pollock Mountain** behind it — one of the most photographed pullouts on the road and deservedly so. **10 min.** Good spot to eat if you're hungry.

11:30 AM — Siyeh Bend

Mile 35. Sweeping curve with a view up Siyeh Creek toward Going-to-the-Sun Mountain. Trailhead for Piegan Pass. **5 min photo stop.**

11:45 AM — Jackson Glacier Overlook

Mile 37. The most accessible glacier view in the park — Jackson Glacier is the 7th largest remaining in Glacier, visible across the valley without hiking a step. Interpretive signs explain the retreat: the park had ~150 glaciers in 1850 and has around 25 today. **15 min.** A distance view, so expect haze to soften it.

12:10 PM — Sunrft Gorge

Mile 41. A 100-yard walk from the pullout to a narrow slot canyon where Baring Creek has cut a deep, sheer channel through red argillite. Easy to miss and genuinely striking. **10 min.**

Optional add-on: from Sunrft Gorge you can walk **0.3 mi down to Baring Falls** — a 25-ft falls in a shaded amphitheater. Adds ~30 min round trip. **Take it if you're ahead of schedule.**

12:45 PM — St. Mary Falls + Virginia Falls (▲ 3.4 mi RT · ~2 hrs)

Trailhead: mile 40, St. Mary Falls trailhead parking. This lot fills — if it's full, park at Sunrft Gorge and walk in.

- **0.8 mi down** through forest burned in the 2015 Reynolds Creek Fire (silver snags with heavy young regrowth — starkly beautiful) to **St. Mary Falls**: a 35-ft, three-tiered falls dropping into a startlingly turquoise pool, crossed by a wooden footbridge. **The bridge is the classic photo.**
- **Continue 0.9 mi further** (climbing gently past several unnamed cascades) to **Virginia Falls** — 50 ft, much bigger, and you can walk right up into the spray. **This one is worth the extra mile.** Most people stop at St. Mary Falls, so Virginia is noticeably quieter.
- **Return is uphill** — about 260 ft back to the car. Not hard, but it's the end of a long day.

Eat lunch at Virginia Falls if you haven't already.

2:45 PM — Sun Point

Mile 42. A rocky promontory jutting into **St. Mary Lake**, with wide views up the valley to Little Chief and Going-to-the-Sun mountains. **0.2 mi walk to the point, flat.** ⚠️ **Wind out on the point is serious** — hold onto hats and phones. **20 min.**

3:15 PM — Rising Sun (*quick stop*)

Mile 45. General store and restrooms. **Last bathroom before Many Glacier.** Grab water — you have a boat tour and no dinner until after 6:30. **15 min max.**

🍔 **Lunch bailout lives here — see below** if the packed sandwiches aren't cutting it.

3:35 PM — Wild Goose Island Overlook

Mile 46. The iconic Glacier photograph — a tiny tree-topped island in St. Mary Lake with mountains stacked behind it. Roadside pullout, no walking.

⚠️ **Manage expectations:** this is a long-distance shot and haze is exactly what kills it. It may be flat and washed out today. Take it anyway, and know the afternoon light is working against you regardless — this view is best at sunrise.

10 min, then go.

3:45 PM — DEPART FOR MANY GLACIER 🕒 **HARD DEADLINE**

Route: east on GTSR to St. Mary → north on **US-89** to **Babb** → west on **Many Glacier Road** (Rt 3) → Many Glacier Hotel. **~22 mi, 40 min.**

⚠️ **Many Glacier Road is rough** — frost heaves and potholes. Don't plan on making up time here. 🚫 **You will lose cell signal.** Anything you need to look up or call, do it before Babb.

4:25 PM — Arrive Many Glacier · pick up tickets

Ticket office is at the boat dock directly behind Many Glacier Hotel. Arrive 30 min before departure — that's the instruction and they mean it.

Change into your warm layers now, at the car. Do not board in a t-shirt.

4:35 PM — Many Glacier Hotel deck

Pick up the tickets, then walk out onto the lakeside deck of the 1915 Swiss-chalet lodge. **This is one of the great hotel views in North America** — Swiftcurrent Lake with Mount Grinnell and the Continental Divide stacked behind it. Ten minutes here while you wait.

5:00 PM — 🚤 **MANY GLACIER BOAT TOUR (~1.5 hrs · booked)**

The trip's marquee experience.

- Board the historic wooden launch across **Swiftcurrent Lake**
- **Short guided walk** (~0.2 mi) over the isthmus to the second boat
- Second launch across **Lake Josephine**, deeper into the valley, with Grinnell Glacier's cirque ahead and peaks closing in on all sides
- Guides narrate geology, glacial history, and wildlife. **Bear sightings on the shoreline are common** from the boat.

It will be cold on the water. You packed for this.

6:30 PM — Off the boat

Lunch — Backup Plan

There is no food between West Glacier and Rising Sun. Logan Pass Visitor Center has restrooms, exhibits, and a bookstore — no café. Whatever's in your pack is what you have from 6:30 AM until mile 45.

Primary plan: packed lunch at **Virginia Falls (~1:45 PM)**, sitting near the base of a 50-ft falls. Substantial snack at **Lunch Creek (11:10 AM)** to bridge the gap from breakfast.

If the sandwiches aren't cutting it — Two Dog Flats Grill, Rising Sun Motor Inn. The only real restaurant between Logan Pass and St. Mary. Full-service: build-your-own burgers, sandwiches, soups, salads. **Mile 45**, already a scheduled stop.

To make it a sit-down lunch, cut Virginia Falls. The afternoon becomes:

Time	Stop
1:45 PM	Off the falls trail (St. Mary Falls only)
2:10 PM	Sun Point
2:45 PM	Two Dog Flats Grill — real lunch
3:40 PM	Wild Goose Island
3:45 PM	Depart for Many Glacier ⌚

A 2:45 lunch and a 7:05 dinner sit together fine.

Also available at St. Mary Village (mile 50, if you end up there): **Curly Bear Café** for sandwiches, **Glacier Perk** for coffee and grab-and-go.

Dinner — Decide Before You Board

Off the boat at 6:30, 40 min from St. Mary, hungry.

★ **Two Sisters Cafe, Babb — recommended.** US-89, **4 mi south of the Many Glacier turnoff, 4 mi north of St. Mary** — directly on your drive back, at the perfect point to break it. **Open Monday until 9:00 PM** (closed Saturdays). Food Network-featured. The **Red Burger** is the signature; they also claim the best **huckleberry pie** in Montana, plus huckleberry margaritas and huckleberry beer. Arrive ~7:05, then 10 min to the hotel. No wait-list scramble with the boat crowd.

Ptarmigan Dining Room, Many Glacier Hotel. 5:00-9:30 PM, no reservations, first-come. Historic 1915 lodge dining room, lake views in evening light, **zero extra driving** — two minutes from the dock. ⚠ Everyone off your boat has the same idea, so **walk straight there** rather than lingering. The Swiss Lounge in the same building is a fine place to wait with a drink.

Babb Bar / Cattle Baron Supper Club, Babb. The steakhouse option, also on the route. Big steaks, ~\$50-60 per person. Reviewers commonly note Two Sisters delivers comparable food for about half.

Snowgoose Grille, St. Mary Village. Your own hotel. **7:00 AM - 9:00 PM daily.** Rustic Montana menu, come-as-you-are. The zero-effort fallback if you're wrecked.

Park Cafe, St. Mary — 406-732-9979. Local institution for pie if you want dessert on its own.

8:00 PM — St. Mary Village — check in

24-hour front desk, so there is zero time pressure. Unload, shower, unpack for the first time all day.

8:50 PM — Sunset

Heavy smoke makes for a deep red, soft-edged sun. **Rising Sun boat ramp** or the **St. Mary Lake overlook** for an open western view.

10:30 PM — Night Sky — Aurora Watch (*conditional*)

This is your best aurora night of the trip and your last at this latitude. The east side's open prairie horizon has no mountains blocking the northern view — clear all the way toward Canada.

But be realistic tonight: Monday night's forecast still carries "Smoke," and smoke scatters light and mutes aurora badly.

- Check **SpaceWeatherLive** before committing
- **Kp 5-6 is the real threshold** at 48°N — below that, sleep
- Tomorrow is the **longest drive of the trip** (7.5 hrs to Gardiner) starting with Many Glacier at 7:50 AM
- **Minimum version:** step outside for five minutes, face north, point your phone camera at the sky (it picks up green before your eye does), then go to bed

Time Budget & Slack

Segment	Planned	Notes
Hungry Horse → Logan Pass	1h 45m	Includes 6 short pullout stops
Logan Pass (parking clock)	3h 00m	Hidden Lake + Highline — fully committed
Logan Pass → Rising Sun	4h 40m	~1h of genuine slack lives here
Rising Sun → Many Glacier	40m	No slack — road is rough

If you run late: cut Virginia Falls first (saves 45 min), then Baring Falls (30 min), then Siyeh Bend and Sun Point (25 min). **Never cut into the 3:45 PM departure.**

If you run early: add Baring Falls, sit longer at Virginia Falls, or walk further out on the Highline. Do *not* add Avalanche Lake.

Quick Reference

St. Mary Village front desk	406-732-4431 (24 hrs)
Boat departure	5:00 PM , dock behind Many Glacier Hotel
At ticket office by	4:30 PM
Leave St. Mary area by	3:45 PM
Logan Pass out by	11:00 AM (3-hr limit)
Logan Pass Visitor Center	8:00 AM – 4:30 PM
Ptarmigan Dining Room	5:00 – 9:30 PM, no reservations
Two Sisters Cafe, Babb	until 9:00 PM Mon
Snowgoose Grille, St. Mary	7:00 AM – 9:00 PM
Two Dog Flats Grill, Rising Sun	lunch backup, mile 45
Sunrise / Sunset	6:18 AM / 8:50 PM
Bathrooms	Logan Pass · Rising Sun · Many Glacier
Cell signal	None past Babb, spotty on GTSR

Trails at a Glance

Ordered by **effort**, easiest first — since elevation is the limiting factor.

Trail	Distance	Gain	Time	Verdict
Sunrift Gorge	100 yd	none	10 min	Do it — no effort, real payoff
Sun Point	0.4 mi RT	none	20 min	Do it — flat, windy, wide lake views
Trail of the Cedars <i>(opt)</i>	1 mi loop	none	45 min	Flat boardwalk — only if skipped yesterday
Highline Trail (partial)	1.5–2 mi RT	~100 ft	1 hr	★ The must-do. Flat, and nothing else like it
Baring Falls <i>(opt)</i>	0.6 mi RT	100 ft	30 min	Add only if the morning went well
St. Mary Falls only	1.6 mi RT	260 ft	1 hr	Do it — descent first, gradual climb back
+ Virginia Falls	+1.8 mi	+200 ft	+45 min	First thing to cut if legs are done
Hidden Lake Overlook	up to 2.7 mi RT	up to 540 ft	1.5–2 hr	Stretch goal — turn around freely
Hidden Lake (to the lake)	+2.4 mi	+765 ft	+2 hr	🚫 Skip — brutal climb out
Avalanche Lake	5.8 mi RT	500 ft	3.5 hr	🚫 Not possible today

Total ascent for the day: ~900–1,000 ft, and roughly half of it is the single Hidden Lake climb. Cut that short and the day becomes genuinely easy.

Conditions and road status checked the evening of August 9, 2026. Verify Going-to-the-Sun Road status and construction delays before departing — a rockfall or overnight closure would change everything.

Sources: NPS — Visiting Logan Pass in 2026 · NPS — Glacier current conditions · NPS — 2026 summer operations · NWS Logan Pass · NWS St. Mary · Ptarmigan Dining Room · Two Sisters Cafe